Task 2: n8n API Integration Workflow

Hacker News Morning Brief | Deepthi Prasanna | 10 November 2026

What it does

Every hour (Schedule Trigger) the workflow fetches the top Hacker News stories, keeps the top 5, enriches each one with its details, builds a digest and sends it by email (Gmail). A Manual Trigger is also connected for testing.

APIs used and why

- **HackerNews Firebase API** (`/v0/topstories.json`, then `/v0/item/{id}.json`): free, no API key, and the two endpoints fit the "list, then enrich" pattern.
- **Gmail** (n8n Gmail node, Google OAuth): free, and the digest arrives in my inbox within seconds.

Workflow steps

Node	Type	Purpose
Schedule / Manual Trigger	Trigger	Runs every 1 hour, or on demand for testing
Get Top Story IDs	HTTP Request	First API call: list of top story IDs
Take Top 5	Code	Transformation: normalizes the response and keeps only the first 5 IDs
Get Story Details	HTTP Request	Second API call: title, score, link, comments for each ID
Build Digest	Code	Removes invalid items, sorts by score (highest first), builds one numbered digest
Top Score > 100?	IF	Threshold: stories above 100 points are clearly popular. True goes to Send Hot Digest, false to Send Normal Digest
Send Hot / Normal Digest	Gmail	Sends the digest with a different subject for each branch
Alert on Failure	Gmail	Error path: emails the error text if an API call fails

Error handling

- Both HTTP Request nodes use **On Error: Continue (using error output)**, so a failed API call never stops the workflow silently.
- The error output goes to **Alert on Failure**, which emails the error message.
- Build Digest throws a clear error if no valid story comes back.

Credentials

No secrets are stored in the workflow JSON. The Gmail login is kept in n8n's Credentials store (Google OAuth) and referenced by the three Gmail nodes.

Successful execution: email output (received 10 Nov 2026, 16:21)

In this run the top story had 625 points, so the IF node took the **true** (Hot) branch.

```
1. Claude Fable 5.2 and Mythos 5.2 (625 points, 820 comments)
   https://www.anthropic.com/claude-fable-and-mythos-5-2
2. USPS now offers official ZIP Code boundary polygons
   (623 points, 318 comments)  https://postalpro.usps.com/zcb
3. Amazon saves millions by replacing Sonnet 4.6 with
   Strands Decider (308 points, 107 comments)
4. Your TV can see through walls (129 points, 48 comments)
   https://maurycyz.com/projects/fading/
5. Queens Public library under ransomware attack,
   e-borrowing suspended (32 points, 11 comments)
```